

# Chapter 1 — The Modern AI-Assisted Engineer

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**Before you can defend AI-assisted development in an interview, you have to be able to define it precisely.** This chapter gives you that definition — and the vocabulary that goes with it.

### What you'll learn

- The actual definition of “AI-assisted development” in 2026 (it has moved fast).
- The **skill stack**: which parts of engineering are now AI's, which are still yours, and which are *new* skills that didn't exist five years ago.
- The **mindset shift** from “code-typist” to “engineering judgment owner” — the single most important framing for the rest of this course.

By the end of the chapter, when an interviewer says “*Tell me how you use AI in your day-to-day work*”, you will not stammer. You will deliver a 60-second answer that distinguishes between *generation*, *review*, *debugging*, and *judgment* — and you'll signal seniority in the first sentence.

### Lessons

1. **01-what-changed.md** — The 2026 baseline. What “AI-assisted development” actually means now. Why the term “vibe coding” is loaded and how to talk about it carefully.
2. **02-the-skill-stack.md** — Five layers of engineering work, mapped to who does what now (you, the AI, or both). The lesson that arms you against “are you still needed?” before Chapter 2 even starts.

3. [03-the-mindset-shift.md](#) — The single biggest difference between juniors who use AI well and seniors who use AI well. The phrase that tells an interviewer you've internalized the shift.

## How long it should take

- 30–40 min reading per lesson.
- 15 min after each lesson rehearsing the answer aloud.
- ~2.5 hours total.

## What you'll have when you're done

- A 30-second definition of AI-assisted development that signals seniority.
- A mental model of the **5 layers of engineering work**.
- One sentence that, if used in an interview, signals you have *internalized* — not just heard about — the mindset shift.

## Before you start

You don't need anything technical. Bring:

- A notebook (paper or digital).
- 5 minutes of think-time before each lesson to recall what you actually did with AI in the last working week.
- An honest read of where you currently fall on the junior–senior–staff continuum, so you can pitch your answers at the right altitude.

Open [01-what-changed.md](#) when you're ready.